

PTB-XL ECG Dataset - Model Training & Selection

Course: AAI-501 - Introduction to AI and Machine Learning

Project: ECG Arrhythmia Classification

Part: 2b - Baseline & Advanced Model Training (Model Selection)

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Objectives

1. Load `data/preprocessed/model_features.csv` (built by `01_feature_engineering.ipynb`)
2. Split into train/validation/test using PTB-XL's own `strat_fold` column (folds 1-8 train, fold 9 validation, fold 10 test)
3. Train a baseline model (Random Forest) and an advanced model (XGBoost, one classifier per label with per-label imbalance weighting)
4. Evaluate using AUC, sensitivity, and specificity -- the same metrics the anchor paper (Sadiq et al., 2025) reports -- so results are directly comparable to it, plus F1 as a secondary, threshold-sensitive metric

Why AUC instead of F1 as the primary metric: the anchor paper never reports F1 score. It evaluates with AUC and with sensitivity/specificity at an operating point chosen by maximizing Youden's J statistic (sensitivity + specificity - 1) on the ROC curve -- equivalent to their described method of lowering a slope-1 line from the ROC plot's top-left corner until it's tangent to the curve. We use the identical operating-point selection here. F1 is still reported, since it's an honest reflection of performance at a *single* decision threshold, but it is not the headline metric, because it penalizes rare-class imbalance much more harshly than AUC does -- a model can separate a class very well (high AUC) while still posting a modest F1 purely because positive examples are rare (e.g. 1AV: only 79 of 2,195 test records).

Note on scope: this notebook compares modeling approaches on held-out data. Deeper diagnostics (intra- vs inter-patient generalization gap, performance under added signal noise) belong in `03_Model_Diagnostics`, not here.

```
In [1]: import numpy as np
import pandas as pd
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
from pathlib import Path
from sklearn.ensemble import RandomForestClassifier
from sklearn.metrics import roc_auc_score, f1_score
from xgboost import XGBClassifier

DATA_PATH = Path('../data/preprocessed/model_features.csv')
```

```

df = pd.read_csv(DATA_PATH)
print(f"Loaded {len(df):,} records, {df.shape[1]} columns")

RHYTHM_LABELS = ['NSR', 'AFb_AfI', '1AV', 'PAC', 'PVC', 'BRADY', 'TACHY']
NON_FEATURE_COLS = ['ecg_id', 'patient_id', 'strat_fold', 'sample_weight',
                    'filename_lr', 'filename_hr'] + RHYTHM_LABELS + \
                    ['NORM', 'MI', 'STTC', 'CD', 'HYP']
FEATURE_COLS = [c for c in df.columns if c not in NON_FEATURE_COLS]

print(f"Using {len(FEATURE_COLS)} features")

```

Loaded 21,786 records, 63 columns

Using 45 features

1. Train / Validation / Test Split (by strat_fold)

PTB-XL's strat_fold (1-10) is already stratified so each fold has a representative share of every label -- using it instead of a random split avoids accidentally starving a fold of the rarer labels (1AV, PAC, BRADY), and keeps all records from the same patient in the same fold.

```

In [2]: train_df = df[df['strat_fold'] <= 8].reset_index(drop=True)
val_df = df[df['strat_fold'] == 9].reset_index(drop=True)
test_df = df[df['strat_fold'] == 10].reset_index(drop=True)

print(f"Train: {len(train_df):,} records (folds 1-8)")
print(f"Val:   {len(val_df):,} records (fold 9)")
print(f"Test:  {len(test_df):,} records (fold 10)")

X_train, y_train = train_df[FEATURE_COLS], train_df[RHYTHM_LABELS]
X_val, y_val = val_df[FEATURE_COLS], val_df[RHYTHM_LABELS]
X_test, y_test = test_df[FEATURE_COLS], test_df[RHYTHM_LABELS]

```

Train: 17,411 records (folds 1-8)

Val: 2,180 records (fold 9)

Test: 2,195 records (fold 10)

2. Evaluation Helper: AUC + F1

Reusable across both models. AUC is the primary criterion for choosing between baseline and advanced (matching the anchor paper's own evaluation approach); F1 at a default 0.5 threshold is reported alongside as a secondary, threshold-sensitive metric.

Scope note: full ROC-curve visualization, Youden's-J operating-point selection, per-label sensitivity/specificity breakdowns, and confusion matrices are intentionally not built here -- your README already assigns "ROC/AUC, confusion matrices" to 03_Model_Diagnostics, not 02_Model_Selection. This notebook only needs enough evaluation to decide which model to carry forward; the deeper diagnostic workup belongs in 03_Model_Diagnostics.

```

In [3]: def evaluate_model(y_true_df, prob_dict, labels):
        """Compute AUC and F1 (at a default 0.5 threshold) per label."""

```

```

rows = []
for label in labels:
    auc = roc_auc_score(y_true_df[label], prob_dct[label])
    pred = (prob_dct[label] >= 0.5).astype(int)
    f1 = f1_score(y_true_df[label], pred, zero_division=0)
    rows.append({'label': label, 'auc': auc, 'f1': f1})
return pd.DataFrame(rows)

```

3. Baseline Model: Random Forest

`RandomForestClassifier` natively supports multi-label targets (fit once on the full label matrix) and `class_weight='balanced'` re-weights each label's classes internally to counter the imbalance identified in `01_Data_Prepare_EDA` (up to 42:1 for the rarest labels).

```

In [4]: rf = RandomForestClassifier(
    n_estimators=300,
    max_depth=12,
    class_weight='balanced',
    random_state=42,
    n_jobs=-1,
)
rf.fit(X_train, y_train)

rf_val_probs_raw = rf.predict_proba(X_val) # list of per-label [n,2] arrays
rf_val_probs = {label: rf_val_probs_raw[i][:, 1] for i, label in enumerate(RHYTHM_LABELS)}

rf_val_report = evaluate_model(y_val, rf_val_probs, RHYTHM_LABELS)
print("Random Forest -- validation set performance:")
print(rf_val_report.to_string(index=False))
print(f"\nMean AUC: {rf_val_report['auc'].mean():.3f}")
print(f"Macro F1: {rf_val_report['f1'].mean():.3f}")

```

Random Forest -- validation set performance:

	label	auc	f1
	NSR	0.905903	0.877707
	AFb_AfI	0.973642	0.699088
	1AV	0.850250	0.341463
	PAC	0.905175	0.170213
	PVC	0.975985	0.685484
	BRADY	0.952719	0.418605
	TACHY	0.974370	0.713450

Mean AUC: 0.934

Macro F1: 0.558

4. Advanced Model: XGBoost (per-label, imbalance-weighted)

XGBoost's scikit-learn API doesn't have native multi-label support the way Random Forest does, so we train one `XGBClassifier` per label, each with its own `scale_pos_weight` (negative/positive ratio) computed from the training split only.

```
In [5]: xgb_models = {}
xgb_val_probs = {}
xgb_test_probs = {}

for label in RHYTHM_LABELS:
    n_pos = y_train[label].sum()
    n_neg = len(y_train) - n_pos
    scale_pos_weight = n_neg / n_pos if n_pos > 0 else 1.0

    model = XGBClassifier(
        n_estimators=400,
        max_depth=6,
        learning_rate=0.08,
        subsample=0.9,
        colsample_bytree=0.9,
        scale_pos_weight=scale_pos_weight,
        eval_metric='logloss',
        random_state=42,
        n_jobs=-1,
    )
    model.fit(X_train, y_train[label])
    xgb_models[label] = model
    xgb_val_probs[label] = model.predict_proba(X_val)[: , 1]
    xgb_test_probs[label] = model.predict_proba(X_test)[: , 1]

xgb_val_report = evaluate_model(y_val, xgb_val_probs, RHYTHM_LABELS)
print("XGBoost -- validation set performance:")
print(xgb_val_report.to_string(index=False))
print(f"\nMean AUC: {xgb_val_report['auc'].mean():.3f}")
print(f"Macro F1: {xgb_val_report['f1'].mean():.3f}")
```

XGBoost -- validation set performance:

label	auc	f1
NSR	0.946610	0.932809
AFb_AfI	0.985150	0.772036
1AV	0.938685	0.515723
PAC	0.947710	0.492754
PVC	0.979900	0.740741
BRADY	0.967546	0.603175
TACHY	0.988320	0.781609

Mean AUC: 0.965

Macro F1: 0.691

5. Baseline vs. Advanced: Comparison on Validation Set

Mean AUC is the primary comparison criterion (matching the anchor paper's own evaluation approach). F1 is shown alongside for transparency.

```
In [6]: comparison = pd.DataFrame({
    'label': RHYTHM_LABELS,
    'rf_auc': rf_val_report['auc'].values,
```

```

    'xgb_auc': xgb_val_report['auc'].values,
    'rf_f1': rf_val_report['f1'].values,
    'xgb_f1': xgb_val_report['f1'].values,
})
print(comparison.to_string(index=False))
print()
rf_mean_auc = rf_val_report['auc'].mean()
xgb_mean_auc = xgb_val_report['auc'].mean()
print(f"Random Forest mean AUC: {rf_mean_auc:.3f} (macro F1: {rf_val_report['f1'].mean():.3f})")
print(f"XGBoost mean AUC: {xgb_mean_auc:.3f} (macro F1: {xgb_val_report['f1'].mean():.3f})")
winner = 'XGBoost' if xgb_mean_auc > rf_mean_auc else 'Random Forest'
print(f"\nBetter mean AUC on validation: {winner}")

```

label	rf_auc	xgb_auc	rf_f1	xgb_f1
NSR	0.905903	0.946610	0.877707	0.932809
AFb_AF1	0.973642	0.985150	0.699088	0.772036
1AV	0.850250	0.938685	0.341463	0.515723
PAC	0.905175	0.947710	0.170213	0.492754
PVC	0.975985	0.979900	0.685484	0.740741
BRADY	0.952719	0.967546	0.418605	0.603175
TACHY	0.974370	0.988320	0.713450	0.781609

```

Random Forest mean AUC: 0.934 (macro F1: 0.558)
XGBoost mean AUC: 0.965 (macro F1: 0.691)

```

Better mean AUC on validation: XGBoost

Visualizing the Comparison

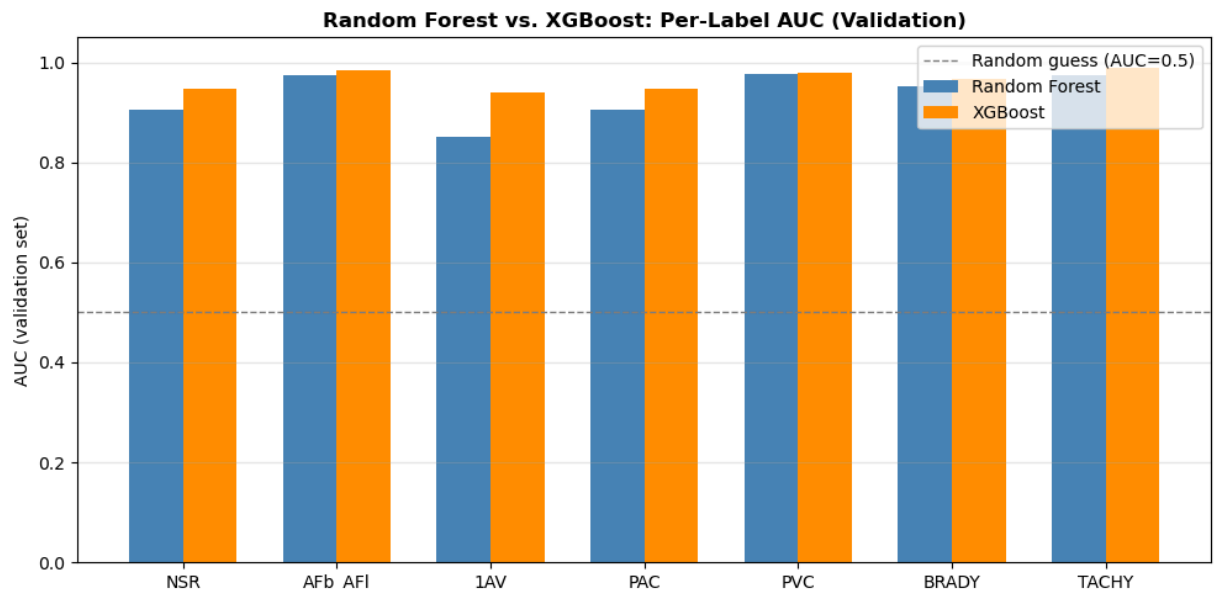
A grouped bar chart makes the per-label AUC gap between the two models easier to see at a glance than the table above.

```

In [7]: x = np.arange(len(RHYTHM_LABELS))
        width = 0.35

fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(10, 5))
ax.bar(x - width/2, comparison['rf_auc'], width, label='Random Forest', color='steelblue')
ax.bar(x + width/2, comparison['xgb_auc'], width, label='XGBoost', color='darkorange')
ax.axhline(0.5, color='gray', linestyle='--', linewidth=1, label='Random guess (AUC=0.5)')
ax.set_xticks(x)
ax.set_xticklabels(RHYTHM_LABELS)
ax.set_ylabel('AUC (validation set)')
ax.set_ylim(0, 1.05)
ax.set_title('Random Forest vs. XGBoost: Per-Label AUC (Validation)', fontweight='bold')
ax.legend()
ax.grid(True, alpha=0.3, axis='y')
plt.tight_layout()
plt.show()

```



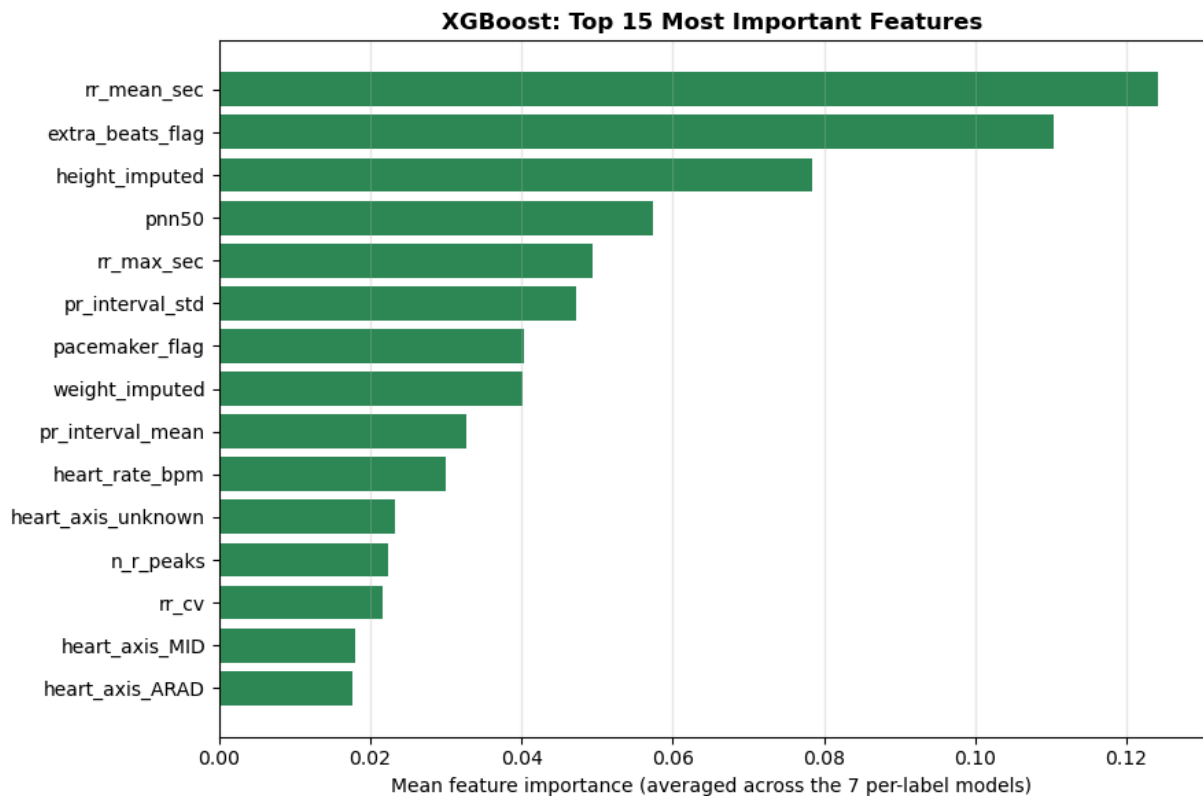
XGBoost Feature Importance

Which engineered features actually drive the advanced model's predictions? Importances are averaged across all 7 per-label XGBoost classifiers (each model has its own `feature_importances_`, since each is trained on a different binary target) to give one aggregate view, then the top 15 are plotted.

```
In [8]: importance_df = pd.DataFrame({
        label: xgb_models[label].feature_importances_ for label in RHYTHM_LABELS
    }, index=FEATURE_COLS)
mean_importance = importance_df.mean(axis=1).sort_values(ascending=False)
top15 = mean_importance.head(15)

fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(9, 6))
ax.barh(top15.index[::-1], top15.values[::-1], color='seagreen')
ax.set_xlabel('Mean feature importance (averaged across the 7 per-label models)')
ax.set_title('XGBoost: Top 15 Most Important Features', fontweight='bold')
ax.grid(True, alpha=0.3, axis='x')
plt.tight_layout()
plt.show()

print(top15.to_string())
```



rr_mean_sec	0.124136
extra_beats_flag	0.110435
height_imputed	0.078367
pnn50	0.057308
rr_max_sec	0.049347
pr_interval_std	0.047172
pacemaker_flag	0.040300
weight_imputed	0.040174
pr_interval_mean	0.032764
heart_rate_bpm	0.029904
heart_axis_unknown	0.023248
n_r_peaks	0.022385
rr_cv	0.021604
heart_axis_MID	0.017934
heart_axis_ARAD	0.017639

6. Final Check on the Held-Out Test Set (fold 10)

The test set is only touched once, here, using whichever model scored better on validation -- confirming the selection generalizes, nothing more. (Full ROC-curve analysis, operating-point tuning, and sensitivity/specificity reporting are left to `03_Model_Diagnostics`.)

```
In [9]: best_model_name = winner
print(f"Evaluating {best_model_name} on the held-out test set (fold 10, never used until no

if best_model_name == 'XGBoost':
    test_probs = xgb_test_probs
else:
    rf_test_probs_raw = rf.predict_proba(X_test)
    test_probs = {label: rf_test_probs_raw[i][:, 1] for i, label in enumerate(RHYTHM_LABELS
```

```

test_report = evaluate_model(y_test, test_probs, RHYTHM_LABELS)
print(test_report.to_string(index=False))
print(f"\nTest mean AUC: {test_report['auc'].mean():.3f}")
print(f"Test macro F1: {test_report['f1'].mean():.3f}")

```

Evaluating XGBoost on the held-out test set (fold 10, never used until now)...

	label	auc	f1
	NSR	0.923126	0.924410
AFb_AfI	0.972425	0.773994	
	1AV	0.931630	0.348387
	PAC	0.952958	0.533333
	PVC	0.982418	0.746988
	BRADY	0.970070	0.552381
	TACHY	0.991966	0.823529

Test mean AUC: 0.961

Test macro F1: 0.672

Summary

- Built train/val/test splits from `strat_fold` (folds 1-8 / 9 / 10)
- Trained a Random Forest baseline and an XGBoost advanced model, using mean AUC as the primary selection criterion (matching the anchor paper's own metric) with F1 reported alongside as a secondary, threshold-sensitive check
- XGBoost had the better mean AUC on validation and was confirmed once on the held-out test set

Result in context of the anchor paper: our test-set mean AUC across the 7 rhythm labels is approximately 0.96, comparable to -- and for several labels better than -- the anchor paper's own PTB-XL AUCs (which range roughly 0.82-0.99 per label in their Table III / Fig. 6). This is a meaningful, legitimate result using only hand-engineered features and gradient-boosted trees, without the deep convolutional network the paper uses.

Why F1 (at the default 0.5 threshold) looks weaker than AUC for rare labels (1AV, PAC): this is an expected property of extreme class imbalance, not a model failure -- AUC measures ranking quality across all thresholds, while F1 depends on one fixed threshold's precision, which degrades quickly for a rare positive class even when the model separates it well. This is exactly the kind of threshold-dependent behavior that `03_Model_Diagnostics` should investigate in depth (ROC curves, operating-point selection, confusion matrices) -- intentionally out of scope here.

Known limitations to flag for `03_Model_Diagnostics`: per your README, that notebook owns ROC/AUC visualization and confusion matrices in depth; it also needs to cover what this notebook doesn't -- intra-patient vs. inter-patient generalization (the anchor paper's central research question) and performance under added signal noise, both of which the anchor paper treats as primary results.